

AI use gets a bad rap, partly due to its impact on the environment. Are individuals the cause of most of the harmful effects of AI or are corporations more to blame as with other things such as CO2 emissions?

Posted by u/Thanderp_MFA • 0 points • 3 comments

We've all seen the statistics and memes about how AI uses a ton of water, produces lots of waste, etc. Oftentimes this comes with the message to stop using generative AI. That's probably fair (and there's lots of other reasons to not support genAI as well) but I also wonder how much of the negative environmental impact is actually caused by individual people prompting an LLM versus large corporations integrating genAI into their own systems, building datacenters, etc.

Is this situation similar to how we're all told to recycle plastics and take the bus to work to cut down on emissions while corporations produce the overwhelming majority of greenhouse gasses in the first place?

Comments

u/GlobalWatts • 1 points • 2026-02-06 04:45 UTC

If the concern is the environmental impact of generative AI, then no, the responsibility is on the corporations profiting off AI. Companies integrating genAI internally or building data centers are all part of that same package.

It's true, those products wouldn't exist without a market of consumers willing to use them. It takes two to tango. But as a society we've long decided that it's better to regulate the handful of companies profiting off this exploitation, than it is to restrict the freedoms of millions of individuals.

And it's not like we can only do one thing at a time. Approaching a problem from multiple angles is an effective strategy. You can ask people to stop using AI while also advocating for the industry to be regulated. Just as you can tell people to recycle plastic bottles while also telling grocery stores to stop wrapping bananas in plastic.

u/PoopMobile9000 • 2 points • 2026-02-05 19:25 UTC

The most harmful effects of AI come from the actual use of it, and its impact on culture and knowledge

u/Technical_Airline205 • 1 points • 2026-02-05 15:10 UTC

I wonder how many posts on reddit are generated by AI agents?